

Empathy + Perspective-Taking

10-Week Leadership Development Program

Daily Habit	Weekly Deliverable	Reading
Before each meeting, write down: 'What might this person be feeling right now? What do they need from me?'	In at least one conversation each day, reflect an emotion back: 'You sound frustrated — is that right?'	A Leader Worth Following — Empathy chapter + Connect (Bradford & Robin) — Support and Empathy chapter

Core Concept

Empathy is frequently misunderstood as 'being nice' or 'agreeing with people.' In leadership, empathy is a cognitive and emotional skill: the ability to understand another person's perspective and emotional state without losing your own.

Brené Brown distinguishes empathy from sympathy: sympathy says 'At least...' (minimizing the experience); empathy says 'I hear that you're in a hard place. I'm here with you.' Empathy requires perspective-taking (seeing things through their lens), staying out of judgment, recognizing emotion in others, and communicating that you understand.

For leaders, empathy is not about abandoning standards or making excuses for poor performance. It is about understanding the human being in front of you well enough to lead them effectively. You cannot motivate, develop, or retain people you don't understand.

""Empathy is feeling with people. Sympathy is feeling for people. Empathy fuels connection. Sympathy drives disconnection.""

— Brené Brown

Framework: Empathy vs. Sympathy vs. Pity

Pity: 'I feel sorry for you.' (Places you above them.)

Sympathy: 'That sounds hard. At least you have your health!' (Acknowledges but minimizes.)

Empathy: 'I can see this is really hard. Tell me more.' (Connects without judgment or silver linings.)

The empathic response requires courage — you have to be willing to sit in discomfort with someone rather than rushing to fix, minimize, or reassure.

Daily Practice

- Pre-meeting ritual: For any 1:1, write one sentence: 'What might [name] be experiencing right now outside of work or in their role?'
- Emotion labeling: When you notice someone seems off — quieter, defensive, distracted — gently name it: 'You seem a bit flat today. Everything okay?'
- The 'What do you need?' question: Instead of assuming what someone needs, ask directly: 'Do you need me to listen, to give advice, or to help solve this?'
- Perspective exercise: After a conflict or tense interaction, write out the other person's experience of that moment — as if you were them.

Leadership Scenarios

Scenario 1

A high performer tells you they're thinking about leaving because they feel undervalued.

Reflection: What's the empathic response? How do you enter their experience before solving the problem?

Scenario 2

A team member makes a significant error on a client deliverable and comes to you visibly shaken.

Reflection: What do they need from you first — accountability, reassurance, or to feel heard?

Weekly Reflection Prompts

Set aside 20 minutes at the end of this week to write your responses. These are for you — be honest.

Reflection 1: Think of a person you find difficult to empathize with. What is their likely positive intention? What fears or pressures might drive their behavior?

Reflection:

Reflection 2: When have you confused empathy with agreement? How did that confusion affect the relationship?

Reflection:

Reflection 3: What is one relationship where you could show more curiosity about the other person's inner experience?

Reflection:

Weekly Habit Tracker

Day	Done?	Notes / Observations
Monday	■	
Tuesday	■	
Wednesday	■	
Thursday	■	
Friday	■	
Saturday	■	
Sunday	■	

End-of-Week Summary

Reflection: What was my biggest leadership learning this week?

Reflection: What will I carry forward into next week?

Reflection: One relationship I invested in this week: